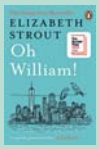
MAKING THE CUT

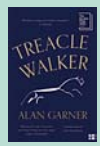
Other novels on this year's Booker Prize shortlist



OH WILLIAM!
By Elizabeth Strout
PENGUIN
₹499; 256 pages

When Lucy Barton, a writer in New York, reconnects with her first husband William, she embarks on a journey into the past that will change the way she looks at the present and how she faces the future.

TREACLE WALKER
By Alan Garner
FOURTH ESTATE
₹399; 160 pages



As it fuses myth and folklore with modern science, this fable tells the story of how Joe Coppack—the boy who wears a patch to correct his lazy eye—is shown a wondrous new world by a wandering healer.



GLORY
By NoViolet Bulawayo
CHATTO & WINDUS
₹999; 416 pages

Taking inspiration from the fall of Zimbabwean dictator Robert Mugabe, this novel breaks down the mechanics of tyranny by swapping human dialogue with an energetic chorus of animal voices.

THE TREES
By Percival Everett
INFLUX PRESS
₹1,018; 334 pages



Even though this novel has all the makings of a literary thriller—a pair of detectives, mounting dead bodies—it is, at its heart, a scathing indictment of the racism and police violence that rattle America.

BOOKS

Small Mercies



Small Things Like These is the slimmest and possibly the most uplifting book on the Booker shortlist

With Christmas around the corner, coal merchant Bill Furlong, the instantly likeable protagonist of Claire Keegan's *Small Things Like These*, has his hands full. Deliveries must be made on the one hand, while his wife and five daughters must be tended to on another. Barring an existential question or two—"Always they carried mechanically on without pause, to the next job at hand. What would life be like, he wondered, if they were given time to think and reflect over things?"—Furlong seems to meet the demands of work and family with a quiet fortitude. Like all good things, the steady calm of his life is interrupted. One morning, he finds a girl locked in a convent's coal shed, scared, dishevelled.

In a book she dedicates to "the women and children who suffered time in Ireland's mother and baby homes and Magdalene laundries", Keegan never once takes her attention away from Furlong. We see through his eyes both the joys of community and the secrets it wishes to sweep out of view. Even though Ireland's Magdalene laundries are believed to have been instituted in the 18th century, Furlong in 1985 had only heard "talk" that girls who toiled at New Ross' Good Shepherds Convent were "of low character", that they were "being reformed, doing penance, by washing stains out of dirty linen".

When Furlong sees the incarcerated Sarah, he finds "the ordinary part of him" simply wanting to get rid of the mess and go on home, but he is faced with a moral dilemma: having seen how girls are being exploited and abused only a distance away, will his home—one where he is raising five dutiful daughters—ever feel sufficient again? Towards the end, Furlong also wonders, "Was it possible to carry on [...] without once being brave enough to go against what was there and yet call yourself a Christian, and face yourself in the mirror?" Thankfully, Keegan gives him the courage.

> Given Small Things Like These is just over 100 pages, it becomes hard to say if it is a novel, novella or a short story

Given its length—just over 100 pages—it becomes hard to categorise *Small Things Like These*. Is this a novella or a short novel, or is it a long short story? That question is perhaps best left for this year's Booker jury to fuss over. For readers and reviewers, this book can be many things. It is, of course, an indictment of the Catholic Church and Irish society—the country's last Magdalene laundry was not closed until 1996. On several occasions, one also thinks that Keegan may have attempted to subvert *A Christmas Carol* with both her politics and sparse prose. But in the end, one feels the author becomes her protagonist. Much like Furlong, who shines his torchlight on Sarah, Keegan illuminates all that is otherwise grim. Nothing is inconsequential. The biggest of actions are made of the smallest of things. ■

Shreevatsa Nevatia



SMALL THINGS LIKE THESE
By Claire Keegan
FABER & FABER
₹399; 128 pages